

German, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

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This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they
are written.

Companion practice lessons live alongside this book at
`code/learning/human-languages/german/lessons/`

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Preface

This is the German volume of a wider project, written for someone starting from zero whose only shared language is English. It works like the others — one word per lesson, taken apart — but the etymology flows through a different channel. Spanish and French are Latin’s children; *German is English’s sibling*. Both are Germanic languages, so German words are most often *direct cousins* of English words, with no Latin middleman: *gut* is English *good*, *Tag* is *day*, *Nacht* is *night*. The gaps between them are not random — they follow the **High German Consonant Shift** ($d \rightarrow t$, $t \rightarrow s$, $k \rightarrow ch$), a single sound-law you can learn once and then use to guess the English cousin on sight (the Romance languages have their own such laws — Latin *-ct-* became Spanish *-ch-*).

Where it lights something up, the book sets German beside its cousins — English always, and Spanish and French as Latin’s side of the family, each form supplied in full so no prior knowledge of them is needed. The richest moment is *Nacht*, where German *Nacht*, English *night*, Spanish *noche*, and French *nuit* turn out to be the same Indo-European word, split four ways.

Same three commitments as the other volumes: one word per lesson, gone deep; the widest *honest* web of cousins; the cultural or grammatical reason, not just the rule. Pronunciation is a short reference at the front, never a gate. Released under CC BY-SA 4.0.

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Pronunciation — a reference, not a chapter

Not to be read before starting. German spelling is largely phonetic — mostly you say what you see — so this page is short. Each lesson names the sounds its word needs and points here for more.

Vowels

- **a** = open *ah*; **o** = *oh*; **u** = *oo* (*gut* = *goot*).
- Umlauts shift the vowel forward: **ä** $\approx$ *eh*, **ü** = the front-rounded *ee* (= French *u*).

Consonants that differ

- **ch** after *a/o/u* = a guttural *loch* sound (*Nacht* = *nahkht*); softer after *e/i*.
- **z** = *ts*; **s** before a vowel = *z*; **ß** = a sharp *ss*.
- **h** at word-start *is* pronounced (unlike Spanish/French).
- **w** = English *v*; **v** = English *f*; **j** = English *y*.
- **Final devoicing**: written *-d/-g/-b* are said *-t/-k/-p* (*Abend* = *AH-bent*, *Tag* = *tahk*).

Two habits

- **Every noun is Capitalized** — *Tag*, *Nacht* — not just names.
- **Final devoicing** (above).

The High German Consonant Shift (a decoding tool)

Not about *saying* words but *recognizing* them: German pushed certain consonants forward, so English and German cousins differ predictably.

English	→ German	example
d	t	good → gut, day → Tag
t	s / ss / z	water → Wasser, that → das
p	pf / f	apple → Apfel, ship → Schiff
k	ch	make → machen, book → Buch

(A *different* shift from Grimm's Law, the older PIE→Germanic change shared by both English and German — see the *Nacht* lesson.)

Chapter 1

Greetings

The German greetings, built from their pieces — a word for “good,” the day-parts, and the three-gender article system. Because German and English are siblings, most words are direct cousins, reshaped by the High German Consonant Shift; where it helps, Spanish and French stand alongside for contrast. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C01-*.md.*

1.1 *hallo* — “hi,” a real cousin this time

Sounds you’ll need

HAH-loh, stress on the first syllable; the *a* is short and open, the *h* fully breathed (German never drops an *h* the way French does).

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

hallo (informal “hi”) — unlike Spanish *hola* (a false friend), German *hallo* and English *hello* are genuine relatives, from the same Germanic hailing call (family of *holla*, *hail*). Where Spanish sends you through Rome, German sends you straight home: because English is Germanic, German words are often *direct* English cousins.

Informal-to-neutral; for polite or first meetings, German uses *Guten Tag*, built over the next lessons.

1.2 *gut* — “good,” and the shift that reshapes German

Sounds you’ll need

goot, one long *u* as in English *boot*; the final *t* stays crisp.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gut (“good”) ← Proto-Germanic **gōdaz* — the *same* word as English **good**. Why *gut*, not *good*? The **High German Consonant Shift**, rule *d*→*t*: *good* → *gut*, *day* → *Tag*, *bed* → *Bett*. Learn the shift once and you can guess the English cousin behind a German word on sight — a single regular sound-law, the same kind of trick that reshaped the Romance words too (Latin *-ct-* became Spanish *-ch-*, *noche*).

Grammar Lens

English splits *good* (adjective) from *well* (adverb); Spanish *bueno/bien*, French *bon/bien*. **German does not** — *gut* is both. “A good day” is *ein guter Tag*; “I’m well” is *mir geht’s gut*. The Romance pair collapses into one German word.

1.3 *der / die / das* — “the,” and *three* genders

Sounds you’ll need

dair / dee / dahss. The *r* of *der* is barely a vowel-like murmur at the back; *die* rhymes with English *see*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der (m.) / **die** (f.) / **das** (n.) ← the old Germanic demonstratives **sa / *sō / *pat* — cousins of English **the** and **that**. Indeed **das** ↔ *that* (the shift *t*→*s*). Not Latin *ille/illa* (that gave Spanish *el/la*, French *le/la*) — Germanic all the way.

Grammar Lens

Latin’s three genders (m./f./neuter) collapsed to two in Spanish and French. **German kept all three:** *der, die, das*. So a noun is one of three classes (learn it *with* its article: *der Tag, die Nacht, das Kind*). English went the other way and dropped gender entirely. (German articles also change by *case* later — *den, dem, des*; ignore that for now.)

1.4 Tag — “day,” straight cousin of English *day***Sounds you’ll need**

tahk: long *a* as in *father*, and a final *-g* that Germans harden to a *k* at the end of a word (*final devoicing*) — so *Tag* rhymes with English *tock*, not *tag*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Tag (masc.) ← Proto-Germanic **dagaz* = English **day**, via the *d*→*t* shift. Note the split from Latin: Spanish *día* and French *jour* come from Latin *dies* — a *different* root from Germanic **dagaz*, which is why *día* and *Tag* look nothing alike. (And every German noun is Capitalized — *Tag*.)

Grammar Lens

der Tag is **masculine**; plural *die Tage* (“the days”). Note the article shift: *der* → *die* in the plural, whatever the gender — German, like French *les*, uses one plural article for all.

1.5 Guten Tag — assembled, and a first German ending

gut + *Tag* = “good day,” the neutral polite hello, *GOO-ten tahk*.

Grammar Lens

Why *guten*, not *gut*? German adjectives agree in gender, number, and case. *Guten Tag* is frozen from “[*ich wünsche Ihnen einen*] *guten Tag*” — “[I wish you a] good day,” where “a good day” is the object (accusative).

A masculine noun there takes *-en*: *guten*. (Don't master the ending system now; just bank that endings track gender+number+case, and watch *Gute Nacht* change it.)

1.6 *Morgen* — “morning,” inside English *tomorrow*

Sounds you'll need

MOR-gun: stress the first syllable; the *-en* sinks to a soft *-un*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Morgen (masc.) ← Proto-Germanic **murganaz* = English **morn-ing**, **morn**, and the *-morrow* of **tomorrow**. (*Morgen* alone also means “tomorrow” in German — context decides.)

Guten Morgen = *gut* + *Morgen* (masc., plural *die Morgen* — unchanged) = “good morning” — *guten* again, same as *Tag*. Used until midday, then *Guten Tag*.

1.7 *Abend* — “evening,” cousin of English *eve*

Sounds you'll need

AH-bent: first-syllable stress, and again final devoicing — the *-d* hardens to *-t*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Abend (masc.) ← Proto-Germanic **ābanþs* = English **eve**, **even(ing)**. Across the languages “evening” has a *different* root in each branch: Germanic *ābanþs* (*Abend*, *eve*) vs Latin “late” words — French *soir* (← *sērus*), Spanish *tarde* (← *tardus*).

Guten Abend = “good evening” (*der Abend*, masc., plural *die Abende*), *guten* once more — the third masculine day-part in a row. The arc: *Guten Morgen* → *Guten Tag* → *Guten Abend*.

1.8. NACHT — “NIGHT,” WHERE ALL FOUR LANGUAGES MEET⁷

1.8 *Nacht* — “night,” where all four languages meet

Sounds you’ll need

nahkht: the *ch* is the throaty *ach*-sound (a scrape at the back of the mouth, like the *ch* in Scottish *loch*), **not** an English *ch*. This is the same throat-scrape as Spanish *j* and Arabic *kh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

die Nacht (fem.) goes back to Proto-Indo-European **nókʷts* — the shared ancestor of every night-word you have. They split by each branch’s sound-laws: Germanic *kt*→*ht* (*Nacht*, *night*), Latin kept *ct* (*noctem*), Spanish softened it to *-ch-* (*noche*), French to *-it-* (*nuit*).

Branch	Word
German / English (Germanic)	Nacht / night
Spanish / French (Latin)	noche / nuit

Nacht is **feminine** (*die Nacht*; plural *die Nächte*, the *a* taking an umlaut → *ä*) — which is why “good night” breaks the *guten* streak.

1.9 *Gute Nacht* — good night, and the ending that changes

gut + *Nacht* = “good night,” *GOO-te nahkht*.

Grammar Lens

Three greetings were *guten* (Tag, Morgen, Abend — masculine). This is *gute*: *Nacht* is **feminine**, and a feminine noun in the “(I wish you a) good —” accusative takes *-e*. So: *guten* (masc.) vs *gute* (fem.) — the German adjective reports the noun’s gender through its ending, the same job Romance adjectives do (Spanish *bueno/buena*, French *bon/bonne*).

Why it’s said this way

Like Spanish *buenas noches* and French *bonne nuit*, *Gute Nacht* is the **bedtime** farewell — not an evening hello (that’s *Guten Abend*). Next

chapter: introducing yourself, and *du* vs. *Sie* (informal vs. formal “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

- *Ich heiße Mira.*
- *Wie heißen Sie?*
- *Ich heiße Arun.*
- *Freut mich.*

Built the same way as the greetings: each piece taken apart first, then assembled — and, because German is English’s sibling, most pieces are direct English cousins. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C02-*.md.*

2.1 *ich* — “I,” the same ancient word as Latin *ego*

Sounds you’ll need

ikh: the *ch* is soft here (a light hiss at the front of the mouth, the “ich-sound”), not the throat-scrape of *Nacht*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ich (“I”) ← Proto-Germanic **ik*, from Proto-Indo-European **eǵ* — the *same* deep root that gave Latin **ego** (and English **ego**), Greek *egō*, and, worn down hardest of all, English **I**. So German *ich*, Latin *ego*, and English *I* are three survivals of one Ice-Age word for “I.”

2.2 *heißen* — “to be called,” the verb English almost lost

Sounds you’ll need

HY-ssen. The ß (*Eszett*) is just a sharp “ss”; *ei* is the vowel of English *eye*. So *heiße* = *HY-ssuh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

heißen (“to be called / to be named”) ← Proto-Germanic **haitanā*. English had this verb too — **hight**, “named,” now archaic (“a knight *hight* Gawain”) — and it survives in **behest** (a command, something “called for”). Where the Romance languages say “I call *myself*” with a reflexive, German uses *heißen* as a plain verb of *being* called — no “myself” needed.

Grammar Lens

One verb, changing its ending. *heißen* is the dictionary (infinitive) form. For each person the ending changes: *ich heiße* (I am called), *du heißt* (you are called), *Sie heißen* (you [formal] are called). This ending-swap is the same machine you’ll see on every German verb.

2.3 *ich heiße...* — “my name is...,” literally “I am called”

ich (I) + *heiße* (am called) = **ich heiße...** — word for word “I am called...,” and the everyday German for “**my name is...**” *Ich heiße Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Why it’s said this way

German also has the literal “my name is”: **mein Name ist...** — where **Name** ← Proto-Germanic **namō*, the *same* root as English **name** and Latin *nōmen* (English **noun**, **nominate**). It’s perfectly correct and common. But *ich heiße* is warmer and more idiomatic — German prefers the *verb* (“I am called”) to the *noun* phrase. (And note *Name* is Capitalized: German capitalizes *every* noun.)

2.4 *du* / *Sie* — “you,” familiar and formal

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

du (familiar “you”) ← Proto-Germanic **pū*, from PIE **tū* — the *same* root as English archaic **thou**, Latin *tū*, and (a cousin) French *tu*. English kept it only in old prayers and Yorkshire; German uses it every day.

Grammar Lens

Two “you”s — and German’s is the odd one out. *du* is for friends, family, children, peers. For respect, German uses **Sie** — which is really the word for “they” (*sie*), promoted to a polite “you” and always **Capitalized** to mark the difference. So German is polite by addressing you in the *third person plural* (“might they...” — a third route to politeness: Spanish coined *usted* (“your grace”), French uses the second-person plural *vous* (“you all”), German borrows the third-person plural *Sie* (“they”). All three dodge the blunt, intimate “you.” When unsure, use *Sie*.

2.5 *wie* — “how,” cousin of English *how*

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

wie (“how”) ← Proto-Germanic **hwī*, from the PIE interrogative root **k^{aw}o-* — the very root behind the English *wh-* words **how**, **what**, **who**, **why** (and, through Latin, the *qu-* of *quo modo*). German *wie* and English *how* are the same question-word, lightly reshaped.

Grammar Lens

Like French (*comment*), German asks a name with “*how*,” not “*what*”: *wie heißen Sie?* is literally “*how* are you called?” Keep the German logic — the question is about the manner of your being called.

2.6 *wie heißen Sie?* — “what’s your name?”

wie (how) + *heißen Sie* (“are you [formal] called”) = literally “**how are you called?**” — the polite “what’s your name?”

Grammar Lens

Word order: verb second. German puts the verb in the *second* slot: *Wie* (1) *heißen* (2) *Sie*? The informal version just swaps in *du* and its ending: *Wie heißt du*? So the same verb, *heißen*, runs the whole exchange — *ich heiße* to give your name, *wie heißen Sie*? to ask for theirs.

2.7 *freut mich* — “pleased to meet you,” i.e. “it gladdens me”

Sounds you’ll need

froyt mikh: *eu* is the vowel of English *boy*; the final *ch* is the soft *ich*-sound again.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

freut mich is short for *es freut mich* (*Sie kennenzulernen*), “it gladdens me (to get to know you).” The verb **freuen** (“to gladden”) is built on **froh** (“glad, joyful”) — the same Germanic *froh/froh-* that surfaces in the English *Frohe Weihnachten* you see at Christmas. To say *freut mich* is to say, warmly, “this makes me glad.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

mich (“me,” the object form) ← Proto-Germanic **mek*, from PIE **me-* — the *same* first-person root as English **me**, **my**, **mine** (and the French *me* of *je m’appelle*). So German *mich*, English *me*, and French *me* are three cousins of one ancient word for “me.” Just as English shifts *I* (subject) to *me* (object), German shifts *ich* to *mich*.

Grammar Lens

German is literally saying “[it] gladdens *me*” — the meeting is what does the gladdening, and you are on the receiving end (the object, *mich*). Fuller forms: *sehr erfreut* (“much pleased”), or the plain *angenehm* (“pleasant / agreeable”), both usable as “pleased to meet you.”

2.8 The whole exchange

German	English
<i>Ich heie Mira.</i>	My name is Mira.
<i>Wie heien Sie?</i>	What's your name?
<i>Ich heie Arun.</i>	My name is Arun.
<i>Freut mich.</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every piece was a Germanic cousin of English: *ich* (I/ego), *heien* (hight/behest), *wie* (how), *freuen* (froh). And German's two habits to keep: it names with a plain verb of *being* called (no "myself"), and it is polite by the *third* person (*Sie* = "they"). Next chapter: *Wie geht's?* ("how's it going?") and answering with *gut* again — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

Having given your name, you ask after the other person — and German asks it with a verb of *motion*: *wie geht es dir?*, “how goes it to you?” Around that question sit the two courtesies that hold every conversation together, *danke* and *bitte*, each of which turns out to be an English word in disguise. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C03-*.md.*

3.1 *danke* — “thank you,” which is really “I think of you”

Sounds you’ll need

DAHN-kuh: a pure open *ah*, the final *-e* sinking to a soft *uh*. Stress the front: *DAHN-kuh*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

danke ← **denken**, “to think.” The old idea: to thank someone is to *keep them in mind* — “I think of you,” “you are in my thoughts.” German *Dank* (“thanks”) and *Gedanke* (“a thought”) are the same root wearing two coats.

And here is the payoff for an English speaker: **English “thank” and “think” are the same word too.** Old English *þancian* (“thank”) and *þencan* (“think”) split from one root — to thank was to *hold in thought*. So *danke* isn’t foreign at all; it is English **thank** with the **think** still visible inside it.

Three different pictures of gratitude, worth holding side by side:

Language	“Thanks”	Literal idea
German	<i>danke</i>	“I think of you”
French	<i>merci</i>	a reward / mercy
Spanish	<i>gracias</i>	grace / favour

Grammar Lens

Dressing it up. *danke schön* — “thank you *nicely*” (*schön* = beautiful, nice) → “thank you very much.” *danke sehr* — “thanks *very*.” *vielen Dank* — “many thanks” (*viel*, “much,” comes later).

3.2 *bitte* — the Swiss-army word: “please” and “you’re welcome”

Sounds you’ll need

BIT-tuh: a short crisp *i*, a clear double-*t*, a soft *-uh* at the end.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bitte is the plea-form of **bitten**, “to ask, to request, to pray.” When you say *bitte* you are, at root, *making a request* — “I ask (this of you).” That verb *bitten* is a close cousin of two English words. **bid** — as in “I *bid* you welcome,” “do as you’re *bidden*” — to ask or command. And **bead** — astonishingly, yes: a *bead* was originally a **prayer**. People counted their prayers (Old English *gebed*) on a string, and the name of the prayer slid onto the little ball you counted it with. So a rosary *bead* is a frozen *request* — exactly what *bitte* still is.

If German gives you one word to overwork, it is *bitte*. It is “please.” It is also “you’re welcome,” and “here you go,” and even “pardon?” One word, and it all comes straight from *asking*:

You say <i>bitte</i> when...	It means	Why (it is all “I ask”)
making a request	please	“I ask you...”
answering <i>danke</i>	you’re welcome	“I ask nothing back”
handing something over	here you go	“I offer, at your request”
you didn’t hear	pardon?	“I ask you to repeat”

Why it’s said this way

For this chapter the key pairing is the courtesy loop: *Danke.* — *Bitte.* (“Thanks.” — “You’re welcome.”) It is the German twin of Spanish *de nada* and French *de rien*, and it closes every small favour.

3.3 *gehen* — “to go,” and it is just English *go***Sounds you’ll need**

In *gehen* the *h* merely **lengthens** the vowel (it is not a breathy English *h*): *GAY-en*. The form you need most is *geht* = *gayt*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

gehen (“to go”) and English **go** descend from the *same* Germanic verb (**gān* / *gehen*) — no Latin detour, no false friend, a straight cognate. When you say *geht*, you are saying *goes*.

Spanish asks “how are you?” with *estar* (“to stand”). French and German both ask it with “**to go**” — *how does it go?* German states its wellbeing as *motion*, exactly like French *ça va*:

Es geht mir gut. = “It goes for-me well.” → “I’m doing well.”

Morphology Spotlight

es = “it” (cognate of English *it*).

geht = “goes.”

mir = “to me, for me” — the *dative*, the “to-whom” form; its partner is *dir*, “to you.”

gut = “well” (Chapter 1 — cognate of English *good*).

So German literally says “**it goes well to me.**” Wellbeing is something that *goes*, and it goes *to* a person.

Grammar Lens

The dative, gently. German marks *the person something happens to* with a special form: *ich* (“I”) → *mir* (“to me”); *du* (“you”) → *dir* (“to you”). “How are you?” will use *dir* or *Ihnen* — “how does it go *to you*?”

For now, just recognize *mir* = “to me.”

3.4 *Wie geht es dir?* — “how are you?”

Sounds you’ll need

German *w* says *v*, so *wie* is *vee*; *ie* is a long *ee*. The whole question: *vee gayt es deer*.

Every piece is already yours: **wie** (“how”), the **du** / **Sie** choice, and **gehen** / **geht** (“to go”). *wie* is used for manner and degree; *du* goes to a friend, and capital-S *Sie* to a stranger or an elder (it is literally “they,” borrowed as respect). Snap them together:

Wie geht es dir? = “How are you?” (informal)
literally: “How goes it to you?”

Morphology Spotlight

wie = “how” · **geht** = “goes” · **es** = “it” · **dir** = “to you” — the dative of *du*, the *mir* → *dir* pair from the last lesson.

Two registers, and only the “you” changes — the same move as the *du*/*Sie* split:

Register	Question
informal (friend, family)	<i>Wie geht es dir?</i> (spoken <i>Wie geht's dir?</i> / just <i>Wie geht's?</i>)
formal (stranger, elder)	<i>Wie geht es Ihnen?</i>

es and *dir* often crush together in speech into *geht's* — *Wie geht's?* is the everyday form, and you can answer it with the *gut* you already have: *Danke, gut!* (“Thanks, well!”).

Grammar Lens

Same question, three metaphors. German *gehen* (go): “how goes it to you?” French *aller* (go): “how does it go?” Spanish *estar* (stand): “how are you standing?” Two of the three put wellbeing in motion; Spanish puts it on its feet.

3.5 *es geht* — the German shrug: “it goes”

Someone asks *Wie geht’s?* You are neither great nor terrible. German’s answer is beautifully understated: **es geht** — just “it goes.” Not *well*, not *badly* — it simply *goes*. That bareness *is* the shrug.

Grammar Lens

In the last lesson you added *gut* to make it positive: *Es geht mir gut*, “it goes well for me.” Say it with **nothing added** — *es geht* — and the very absence of a “well” or “badly” makes it mean “eh, so-so, it’s going, I’m getting by.” The understatement carries the whole meaning.

Your German answer ladder for *Wie geht’s?*:

Answer	Sense
<i>Sehr gut!</i> / <i>Gut, danke</i>	very well / well, thanks
<i>Es geht</i>	so-so, okay-ish
<i>So lala</i>	so-so (a sing-song “meh”; <i>lala</i> is just filler)
<i>Nicht so gut</i>	not so well

Why it’s said this way

The cross-track shrug collection, now four deep: German **es geht** (“it goes”), French **comme ci, comme ça** (“like this, like that”), Spanish **más o menos** (“more or less”) or **regular**, Italian **così così** (“so so”).

3.6 The whole exchange

No new words — this chapter’s atoms (*danke, bitte, gehen, wie geht’s, es geht*) assemble into a real exchange, formal and informal, picking up right where the introduction of Chapter 2 left off.

Formal (a stranger, an elder):

— *Guten Tag. Wie geht es Ihnen?*
 — *Danke, gut. Und Ihnen?*
 — *Es geht.*
 — [after a small favour] — *Danke! — Bitte.*

Informal (a friend):

- *Hallo! Wie geht's?*
- *Gut, danke, und dir?*
- *So lala.*

Grammar Lens

The glue is *und dir?* / *und Ihnen?* — “and you?” (*und* = “and,” cognate of English **and**), the German twin of Spanish *¿y tú?* and French *et toi?*. Note that it takes the **dative** (*dir* / *Ihnen*), because it is short for “how goes it *to you?*”

Built this chapter

<i>danke</i>	thanks (← <i>denken</i> , “to think”; English <i>thank</i> = <i>think</i>)
<i>bitte</i>	please / you’re welcome (← <i>bitten</i> , “to ask”; English <i>bid</i> ,
<i>gehen</i> / <i>geht</i>	“to go,” the state-verb (= English <i>go</i>)
<i>Wie geht es dir?</i> / <i>Ihnen?</i>	how are you — informal / formal
<i>gut</i> / <i>es geht</i> / <i>so lala</i> / <i>nicht so gut</i>	the answer ladder

Which verb carries German’s “how are you?”, and what English word is it? *gehen* = *go*. Which two of our three tracks use “to go,” and which uses “to stand”? Go: German and French; stand: Spanish. Next chapter: farewells — *auf Wiedersehen*, *tschüss*, *bis bald*.

Chapter 4

Farewells

You can open a German conversation; now close it. German parts formally with a promise to *see each other again*, casually with a word that has travelled across three languages, and softly with *bis...* — “until...” — plus a word for time. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-CO4-*.md.*

4.1 *auf Wiedersehen* — “goodbye,” i.e. “till we see again”

Sounds you’ll need

owf VEE-der-zay-en. German *w* says *v*, and *ie* is a long *ee*, so *Wieder* = *VEE-der*. Nouns are capitalized in German, so *Wiedersehen* takes a capital W.

The formal goodbye is **auf Wiedersehen**, and it is the exact twin of French *au revoir*: both mean “until we see each other again.” It breaks cleanly into three pieces:

Morphology Spotlight

auf = “on, upon” (cognate of English *up* / *of*).

wieder = “again” — not, as you might guess, kin to *withering*, but to the *with-* of **withdraw**; think “back.”

sehen = “to see” — a **straight cognate of English see** (both from Germanic **sehwan*).

So *auf Wiedersehen* = “on the seeing-again” → “until we see each other again.” Put it beside the other two tracks and the picture is lovely:

Language	Goodbye	Metaphor
German	<i>auf Wiedersehen</i>	“till we see again”
French	<i>au revoir</i>	“till the re-seeing ”
Spanish	<i>adiós</i>	“to God ”

Why it’s said this way

German and French shake hands on a *re-seeing*; Spanish commends you to God. (*Wiedersehen* even works as a noun on its own — *ein Wiedersehen* is “a reunion.”)

4.2 *tschüss* — the casual “bye” that used to say “to God”

Sounds you’ll need

tschüss starts with the *ch* of English **church**: *chüss*. The **ü** is the front-rounded vowel — say *ee* with rounded lips — so *tschüss* is roughly *chuess*, short and clipped.

Between friends, Germans rarely say the full *auf Wiedersehen* — they say **tschüss**, a breezy “bye.” And it hides one of the best secrets in this whole chapter.

Etymology

tschüss looks purely German, but trace it back and it leaves the country. French **adieu** (“to God”) → borrowed into **Walloon** (a language of southern Belgium) as **adjûs** → carried north into **Low German** dialects as **atschüs** / **atschüss** → clipped to modern **tschüss**.

So the chain is *adieu* → *adjûs* → *atschüss* → *tschüss* — and since *adieu* is à *Dieu*, “to God,” the casual German *tschüss* is a far-travelled cousin of French **adieu** (“to God”) and Spanish **adiós** (“to God”): all three the same little blessing, just worn down more and more. The friendliest, most throwaway German goodbye is secretly the most solemn one.

Why it’s said this way

You will also hear **tschau** — that one is Italian *ciao*, borrowed straight.

Grammar Lens

Register. *tschüss* — friends, family, peers, casual shops; never in a formal meeting. *auf Wiedersehen* — strangers, elders, officials, the telephone. It is the same split you have drilled all along (*du* vs *Sie*): pick the parting to match the relationship.

4.3 *bis bald* — “see you soon”**Sounds you’ll need**

bis = *biss* (short *i*). *bald* = *balt* — a final *d* always hardens to *t* in German (final devoicing). The whole phrase: *biss BALT*.

German’s soft goodbyes all start with **bis**, “until” — the German version of Spanish *hasta* and French *à*. First up: **bis bald**, “until soon” → “see you soon,” the twin of *hasta pronto* and *à bientôt*.

Morphology Spotlight

bis = “until, up to” — German’s farewell preposition. Just as Spanish builds *hasta luego* / *hasta mañana* and French builds *à bientôt* / *à demain*, German builds *bis* + a time word.

bald = “soon.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

bald (“soon”) ← Old High German *bald*, which meant “**bold**, quick, brave” — and that is the *same word as English bold*. The sense drifted: what is done *boldly* is done *quickly* → *soon*. So German “soon” and English “bold” are one word; German kept the speed, English kept the courage.

Grammar Lens

The *bis...* family.

German	“Until...”	Spanish / French twin
<i>bis bald</i>	soon	<i>hasta pronto</i> / <i>à bientôt</i>
<i>bis später</i>	later	<i>hasta luego</i> / <i>à plus tard</i>
<i>bis morgen</i>	tomorrow	<i>hasta mañana</i> / <i>à demain</i>

bis später — “until later” — uses *später*, “later,” the comparative of *spät*, “late.” *bis morgen* comes next.

4.4 *bis morgen* — “see you tomorrow” (and *Morgen* comes back)

Sounds you’ll need

The German *r* is the guttural one, made at the back: *morgen* = *MOR-gen*. Whole phrase: *biss MOR-gen*.

Parting for the day: **bis morgen**, “until tomorrow.” It brings back **Morgen** — the “morning” from your very first chapter (*Guten Morgen!*) — now doing a second job.

Morphology Spotlight

bis = “until” (last lesson).

morgen = “tomorrow” and “morning,” exactly the double meaning of Spanish *mañana* and French *demain*. German simply uses the one word for both: *Guten Morgen!* = “Good **morning!**”; *bis morgen* = “until **tomorrow.**” When it means “morning” it is a capital-M noun, *der Morgen*; as “tomorrow” it is lowercase, *morgen*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Morgen is a straight relative of English **morning** and the old word **morrow** — “see you on the *morrow*” is *bis morgen* almost word for word, and “tomorrow” is literally “to (the) morrow.” So all three tracks make “tomorrow” out of “morning”: German **Morgen**, Spanish **mañana** (← Latin *māne*), French **demain** (← *dē māne*). Same idea, three routes.

Grammar Lens

The *bis...* farewells, complete. You now have German’s full soft-goodbye set — *bis bald* (soon), *bis später* (later), *bis morgen* (tomorrow) — plus *auf Wiedersehen* (formal) and *tschüss* (casual).

4.5 Saying goodbye, start to finish

No new words. The farewells now close a real conversation and fold back into everything since *hallo*.

You're...	Say
formal / to a stranger	<i>Auf Wiedersehen.</i>
casual / to a friend	<i>Tschüss.</i>
meeting again soon	<i>Bis bald.</i>
leaving for the day	<i>Bis morgen.</i>

Everything from Chapters 1–4, in one exchange:

- *Hallo! Ich heie Anna. Wie heien Sie?*
 — *Ich heie Peter. Freut mich.*
 — *Wie geht es Ihnen?*
 — *Danke, gut. Und Ihnen?*
 — *Sehr gut. Also...bis morgen, Peter.*
 — *Bis morgen, Anna. Auf Wiedersehen!*

Between friends, that last line becomes *Tschüss, bis morgen!*

Built this chapter

<i>auf Wiedersehen</i>	the formal goodbye (“on the seeing-again”; <i>sehen</i> = <i>see</i> ; twin of <i>au revoir</i>)
<i>tschüss</i>	casual bye (secretly <i>adieu</i> , “to God,” cousin of <i>adiós</i>)
<i>bis bald / später / morgen</i>	soon / later / tomorrow — <i>bis</i> + a time, like <i>hasta</i> and <i>à</i>

Which German goodbye promises a “re-seeing,” and which language matches it? *Auf Wiedersehen*; French *au revoir*. What does the casual *tschüss* secretly mean? “To God.” You can now hold a whole German exchange, hello to goodbye. Next chapter: the first verbs, and your first self-built sentence.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now you have assembled fixed phrases. This chapter hands you the machine itself: the regular German verb, whose endings you learn once and then apply to thousands of words. Three verbs — *wohnen*, *machen*, *lernen* — and then your first sentence built from parts nobody handed you. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C05-*.md.*

5.1 *wohnen* — “to live,” and the regular German verb

Sounds you’ll need

German *w* is an English *v*: *wohnen* = *VOH-nen*. The *h* here merely **lengthens** the *o* (*woh-* = a long *oh*); it is not breathy.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

wohnen (“to live, to dwell”) ← Old High German *wonēn*, “to dwell, to be accustomed, to be content” — dwelling and *being used to* a place were the same idea. That root survives in English, just barely: **wont**, “accustomed” (*as is his wont*), and *won’t*’s distant cousin; the archaic **won** / **wone**, “to dwell.” It is also kin to **win** and **wish** — all from a root about *striving for* or *being content*.

Grammar Lens

The regular (weak) present tense. Drop the *-en* to get the stem *wohn-*, then add the endings. This one table is the pattern behind thousands of German verbs.

Person	Ending	<i>wohnen</i> →
<i>ich</i> (I)	-e	<i>ich wohne</i>
<i>du</i> (you)	-st	<i>du wohnst</i>
<i>er / sie / es</i> (he / she / it)	-t	<i>er wohnt</i>
<i>wir</i> (we)	-en	<i>wir wohnen</i>
<i>ihr</i> (you all)	-t	<i>ihr wohnt</i>
<i>sie / Sie</i> (they / you formal)	-en	<i>sie wohnen</i>

Unlike French — where *-e*, *-es*, *-ent* are all silent — **German endings are audible**: *wohne* / *wohnst* / *wohnt* really do sound different. So you could almost tell who is speaking from the ending alone. German nevertheless *keeps* the pronoun; why, comes later in this chapter. Now you can answer a *wo* (“where”) question:

Ich wohne in Berlin. = “I live in Berlin.”

5.2 *machen* — “to make / to do,” and it is just English *make*

Sounds you’ll need

The *ch* after *a* is the raspy *ach*-sound, made in the throat like the *ch* of Scottish *loch*: *machen* = *MAKH-en*, with a clean open *ah*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

machen ← Germanic *makōn*, “to make, to shape, to fit together” — the *same word as English make*. The German *k*-sound became the *ch* rasp along the way, by the **High German consonant shift**: *make* → *machen*, just as *ik* → *ich* and *book* → *Buch*. So *machen* is *make*, wearing German pronunciation.

German uses it for both “make” and “do”:

Ich mache einen Kuchen. = “I’m making a cake.”
Was machst du? = “What are you doing?”

Grammar Lens

Same weak endings. *ich mache · du machst · er macht (-e / -st / -t); wir machen · ihr macht · sie machen.* Identical to *wohnen* — nothing new to learn. That is the payoff of a regular pattern.

Person	<i>machen</i> →
<i>ich</i>	<i>mache</i>
<i>du</i>	<i>machst</i>
<i>er / sie / es</i>	<i>macht</i>
<i>wir</i>	<i>machen</i>
<i>ihr</i>	<i>macht</i>
<i>sie / Sie</i>	<i>machen</i>

5.3 *lernen* — “to learn,” and it *is* English *learn***Sounds you’ll need**

The German **r** is a soft guttural at the back of the throat: *lernen* = *LER-nen*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

lernen ← Germanic *liznōjan*, “to learn, to get to know” — the *same root as English learn*. Its close relatives are lovely: **lore**, the body of what has been *learned* (folklore, the *lore* of a craft); and **last** (a shoemaker’s *last*) together with Gothic *lais* (“I know”), which share the deep root — the idea of *following a track* to knowledge. So *lernen* is not foreign at all: it is *learn*, and its noun *die Lehre* (“the teaching, the lesson”) is *lore*.

Grammar Lens

The same weak endings, one last time — *-e / -st / -t* in the singular, *-en / -t / -en* in the plural. Three verbs, *wohne*, *mache*, *lerne*, one pattern: you now conjugate the regular German present.

Person	<i>lernen</i> →
<i>ich</i>	<i>lerne</i>
<i>du</i>	<i>lernst</i>
<i>er / sie / es</i>	<i>lernt</i>
<i>wir</i>	<i>lernen</i>
<i>ihr</i>	<i>lernt</i>
<i>sie / Sie</i>	<i>lernen</i>

5.4 *Ich lerne Deutsch* — your first real sentence

Sounds you'll need

Deutsch = *DOYTCH*: *eu* is the *oy* vowel, and *tsch* is the *tch* of English *match*. The whole sentence: *ikh LER-neh DOYTCH*.

Everything pays off: you take a **verb** you have conjugated and a **noun**, and build a sentence nobody handed you — *Ich lerne Deutsch*, “I’m learning German.” (There is no separate “am ...-ing” in German: *ich lerne* covers both “I learn” and “I am learning.”)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Deutsch = “German” (the language), and note it is **capitalized**, because it is a noun here. It comes from Old High German **diutisc**, “of the people, of the folk” — from **peudō*, “the people.” The Germanic tribes simply called their own tongue “the people’s [language],” as opposed to Latin.

That “folk” root spread far: English **Dutch** is the *same* word (it once meant all continental West Germanic; English later narrowed it to the Netherlands); **Teutonic** comes via Latin *Teutonicus* from the same **peudō*; Italian calls Germany *Tedesco* and French had *thiois* — all echoes of *diutisc*.

Morphology Spotlight

Ich (I) + **lerne** (learn, from *lernen*) = **Ich lerne Deutsch**.

Grammar Lens

Why German keeps the pronoun. German keeps *ich, du, er...* — like French, and unlike Spanish or Italian, which drop it. But for a *different reason*. Spanish drops *yo* because *hablo* already says “I.” French keeps *je* because its endings are *silent*. German’s endings are *not* silent (*wohne* / *wohnst* / *wohnt* differ audibly) — yet German still needs the pronoun because its **grammar demands an overt subject**: a German sentence is built around the verb sitting in second position, with something before it. So: Spanish **drops**, French keeps for **sound**, German keeps for **structure**.

Swap the pieces and the pattern keeps working: *Ich wohne in Berlin.* ·
Was machst du?

5.5 Making sentences with weak verbs

For the first time you are *building* German sentences from a pattern, not reciting phrases. Run each verb through *ich / du / er*:

Verb	<i>ich</i>	<i>du</i>	<i>er</i>
<i>wohnen</i> (to live)	<i>wohne</i>	<i>wohnst</i>	<i>wohnt</i>
<i>machen</i> (to make/do)	<i>mache</i>	<i>machst</i>	<i>macht</i>
<i>lernen</i> (to learn)	<i>lerne</i>	<i>lernst</i>	<i>lernt</i>

The same endings every time (**-e** / **-st** / **-t**), and — unlike French — you can *hear* them all. You still keep the pronoun, because German needs an overt subject.

Now say something real:

— *Wo wohnst du?* — *Ich wohne in Berlin. Und du?*
 — *Ich wohne in Wien. Was machst du?*
 — *Ich lerne Deutsch!* — *Sehr gut!*
 — *Danke!* — *Bitte.*

 Built this chapter

the regular (weak) present	drop <i>-en</i> , add <i>-e/-st/-t/-en/-t/-en</i> ; the endings are audible
<i>wohnen</i>	← <i>wonēn</i> → English <i>wont</i>
<i>machen</i>	← <i>makōn</i> → English <i>make</i> ; <i>Was machst du?</i>
<i>lernen</i>	← <i>līznōjan</i> → English <i>learn, lore</i>
<i>Ich lerne Deutsch</i>	first self-assembled sentence (<i>Deutsch</i> ← <i>diutisc</i> , “of the people” →)
the pronoun rule	Spanish drops <i>yo</i> ; French keeps <i>je</i> (silent endings); German keeps

What are the three singular weak endings, and are they audible? *-e / -st / -t*; yes — unlike French. Give the “I” forms of the three verbs: *ich wohne, ich mache, ich lerne*. German now moves in real sentences.

Chapter 6

Numbers One to Ten

Here is where German feels *closer to English than any Romance language does*. German’s numbers are not borrowed from Latin — they are German’s own Germanic words, and they are the near-twins of English *one, two, three, four, five*. One sound-law explains every difference. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C06-*.md.*

6.1 *eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf* — counting to five

Sounds you’ll need

eins, zwei, drei all carry the *ei* = English “eye” sound: *eyns, tsvy, dry*.
fünf: the *ü* is “ee” said with rounded lips; *fünf* $\approx$ *fewnf*.

German	English twin	shared ancestor	Latin cousin
<i>eins</i> (1)	one (and <i>a/an</i>)	* <i>óynos</i>	<i>ūnus</i>
<i>zwei</i> (2)	two (<i>tw-</i> → <i>zw-</i>)	* <i>dwóh₁</i>	<i>duo</i>
<i>drei</i> (3)	three (<i>th-</i> → <i>d-</i>)	* <i>tréyes</i>	<i>trēs</i>
<i>vier</i> (4)	four	* <i>k^wetwóres</i>	<i>quattuor</i>
<i>fünf</i> (5)	five (<i>f...f</i>)	* <i>pénk^we</i>	<i>quīnque</i>

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

German and English are **siblings**; Latin is a **cousin**. So *drei* is not from Latin *trēs* — both descend from one prehistoric word, and **Grimm’s Law** is the recipe for the differences: an old **t** became Germanic **th/d** (*trēs* → **three** → *drei*), and an old **p** became **f** (**pénk^we* → **five** / *fünf*, while Latin kept it as *quīnque*). Say *fünf* and **five** back to back — same

word, one *p*-turned-*f* apart.

Grammar Lens

eins → *ein* / *eine* (**one = a/an**). Like English *one/an* and Spanish *uno/un*, German **eins** becomes the article **ein** (masculine/neuter) / **eine** (feminine) before a noun: *ein Kaffee* “a/one coffee,” *eine Katze* “a/one cat.” The counting form is *eins*; the article drops the -s. The other numbers do not change for the article.

6.2 *sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn* — finishing the count

The rest of the way to ten — and again, each is the twin of its English number, with Latin as the cousin one sound-shift away. Two of them show Grimm’s Law beautifully.

Sounds you’ll need

acht: the *ch* is the raspy back-of-throat sound (as in *Bach*): *akht*. It matches the *gh* in English *eight* — both were once a real throat sound.
neun = *noyn* (the *eu* = “oy”).

German	English twin	shared ancestor	Latin cousin
<i>sechs</i> (6)	six	* <i>swéks</i>	<i>sex</i>
<i>sieben</i> (7)	seven	* <i>septm</i>	<i>septem</i>
<i>acht</i> (8)	eight	* <i>oktō</i>	<i>octō</i>
<i>neun</i> (9)	nine	* <i>néwn</i>	<i>novem</i>
<i>zehn</i> (10)	ten	* <i>dékm</i>	<i>decem</i>

Etymology

Two showpieces of **Grimm’s Law**:

zehn ↔ **ten** ↔ *decem*: an old **d** became Germanic **t** — so Latin kept *decem*, English shifted to **ten**, and German went one hop further (*t* → *z*) to *zehn*. Same number, three snapshots of one consonant drifting.

acht ↔ **eight** ↔ *Nacht/night*: the German *-cht-* answers English *-ght-* every time (*acht/eight*, *Nacht/night*, *Licht/light*) — a fossil of a

throat sound both languages once had.

Grammar Lens

German borrowed the *months*, not the numbers. English and German both took their **month names straight from Latin** — *September, Oktober, November, Dezember* in German too. So the same “off by two” trick works: those months mean Latin **7, 8, 9, 10** (the Roman year began in March), even though German’s own numbers *sieben/acht/neun/zehn* look nothing like them. The numbers are home-grown; the month labels are Latin imports.

Give 1–10 in German: *eins, zwei, drei, vier, fünf, sechs, sieben, acht, neun, zehn*. None of them is borrowed from Latin — they are Germanic **twins** of the English numbers, cousins of Latin via **Grimm’s Law**. Next chapter builds on this toward the days of the week, and after that, telling the time.

Chapter 7

The Days of the Week

Just as with the numbers, German goes its **Germanic** way here — and lands right next to English. The Romans named the weekdays for planet-gods (*Mars, Mercury, Jupiter, Venus*); the Germanic peoples swapped in *their own* gods, and German and English inherited that same set. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C07-*.md.*

7.1 Montag to Freitag — the gods of the Germanic week

Sounds you'll need

-tag (“day”) is easy; watch *Freitag* = *FRY-tahk*, with the *ei* = English “eye.”

Mittwoch ends in the raspy *ch*: *MIT-vokh*.

Morphology Spotlight

The pattern: [Germanic god] + *Tag* (“day”). *Tag* = “day” (cousin of English **day**). Before it stands a god — the Germanic counterpart of the Roman planet.

German	god	= English	(Roman planet it is named after)
<i>Montag</i>	the Moon (<i>Mond</i>)	Monday	Moon
<i>Dienstag</i>	Tiw/Ziu , the war-god	Tuesday	Mars
<i>Mittwoch</i>	(none — “mid-week”)	Wednesday (Woden)	Mercury
<i>Donnerstag</i>	Donar = Thor (<i>Donner</i> “thunder”)	Thursday	Jupiter
<i>Freitag</i>	Frija/Frigg , love-goddess	Friday	Venus

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Donnerstag ↔ **Thursday**. *Donner* is German for “thunder,” and *Donar* was the Germanic thunder-god — the one the Norse called **Thor**. So *Donnerstag* = “Thor’s day” = **Thursday**, standing in for the Roman *Jupiter* (the sky-thunder king). Same god-slot, three names.

Why it’s said this way

Mittwoch is the odd one out. It ought to be “Wodan’s day” (as English keeps **Wednesday** = Woden’s day). But the medieval Church disliked naming a day for the chief pagan god, so German replaced it with plain **Mittwoch**, “mid-week” — a religious edit, just like Portuguese numbering its days.

7.2 *Samstag* and *Sonntag* — the German weekend

Two weekend days, and one more surprise: German’s Saturday is *not* Saturn’s day — it is the **Sabbath**, sharing its root with the Romance languages, not with English *Saturday*. Sunday, though, stays the Sun’s.

German	←	meaning	note
<i>Samstag</i>	<i>Sabbat</i> ← Greek <i>sábbaton</i> ← Hebrew <i>shabbāt</i>	the “ Sabbath ”	<i>not</i> Saturn!
<i>Sonntag</i>	<i>Sun</i> + <i>Tag</i> (<i>Sonne</i> “sun”)	“the Sun’s day”	= English Sunday

Etymology

Samstag surprises everyone: where English kept the Roman planet (**Saturday** = Saturn), German took the **Sabbath** — Greek *sábbaton* (from Hebrew *shabbāt*, “to rest”) travelled up through the early Church

into German as *Sabbat* → *Samstag*. It reached German through Greek-speaking Christians. So German *Samstag* and Spanish *sábado* are the *same* Sabbath, while English alone still points at Saturn.

Why it's said this way

In northern Germany you also hear **Sonnabend**, “Sun-eve,” the evening before Sunday.

Sonntag is simply “the **Sun**’s day,” *Sonne* + *Tag* — the exact twin of English **Sunday**. Here Germanic and English agree, and the Church did not rename it (unlike Romance, which made it “the Lord’s day,” *domingo/dimanche*). It is a rare Germanic day the Church left alone.

All seven, in order: *Montag*, *Dienstag*, *Mittwoch*, *Donnerstag*, *Freitag*, *Samstag*, *Sonntag*. German names its days for *gods*, like English, not for planets — with two edits: *Mittwoch* (“mid-week,” for Woden) and *Samstag* (the Sabbath, for Saturn). Next chapter builds on this toward telling the time.

Chapter 8

Telling the Time

Something new happens here. German's numbers were homegrown (*eins*, *zwei*), and its weekdays were Germanic gods (*Donnerstag*). But its word for the **clock** — **Uhr** — is borrowed from Latin, while noon and midnight swing back to native German. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C08-*.md.*

8.1 *Uhr* — the clock, and a Roman word in the German day

Time-keeping came to the German world with Roman and monastic clocks, and the Latin word rode in with them.

Sounds you'll need

Uhr = *oor*, a long *u* then a soft *r*: one syllable.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Uhr comes from Latin **hōra**, “hour” — the *same* word that became French *heure*, Italian *ora*, and English **hour**. German took it in (through medieval Latin and Low German *ūr(e)*) and made it *Uhr*.

That is the striking part: three layers of the German day, three different origins.

what	German	origin
the numbers	<i>eins, zwei, drei</i>	native Germanic (twins of English)
the weekdays	<i>Montag, Donnerstag</i>	Germanic gods (Latin <i>months</i>)
the clock	<i>Uhr</i>	Latin loan (<i>hōra</i>)

German kept its own numbers and gods, but for the *machine that measures hours* it reached for Rome. German also has a native word, **Stunde**, “an hour’s span” — but for clock-reading, “o’clock,” it is *Uhr*.

Grammar Lens

“**Es ist ... Uhr.**” To tell the time, German says **es ist** (“it is”) + the number + **Uhr**:

Es ist ein Uhr. — “It is one o’clock.”

Es ist zwei Uhr. — “It is two o’clock.”

Es ist zehn Uhr. — “It is ten o’clock.”

Uhr does not add a plural here (not *zwei Uhren* for the time) — it works like English **o’clock**: *zwei Uhr* = “two o’clock.” (*Uhren*, the plural, means “clocks,” the objects.)

8.2 *Mittag* and *Mitternacht* — the native middle of day and night

The clock-word *Uhr* was Latin. But noon and midnight swing back to **native German**: *Mittag* and *Mitternacht* are plain Germanic compounds — “the day’s middle” and “the night’s middle.”

Morphology Spotlight

Both start with **Mitte**, “middle” (cousin of English **mid**, **middle**, and of Latin *medius*).

German	=	literally
<i>Mittag</i>	<i>Mitte</i> + <i>Tag</i>	“ mid-day ” (noon)
<i>Mitternacht</i>	<i>Mitter</i> (<i>Mitte</i>) + <i>Nacht</i>	“ mid-night ” (midnight)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Mittag = “mid-day.” *Tag* (“day”) you met in *Montag*, *Dienstag*; put “middle” in front and you get noon. Its meaning matches French *midi* (*medius diēs*) exactly — same idea, but German built it from its *own* words instead of borrowing the Latin one.

Mitternacht = “mid-night.” *Nacht* (“night”) is the twin of English **night** (remember *acht/eight*, *Nacht/night* — the *-cht/-ght* pair). So

Mitternacht and English **midnight** are the same compound in two Germanic tongues.

To tell the time with them: *Es ist Mittag.* — “It is noon.” *Es ist Mitternacht.* — “It is midnight.”

So German splits the day three ways by origin: **Uhr** (Latin) for the hours, **Mittag/Mitternacht** (native) for its pivots. Next chapter builds on this toward months and family.

Chapter 9

Months and Seasons

The German year is built from two different quarries. Its twelve *months* were carried north from Rome, name and all; its four *seasons* are home-grown Germanic, one of them the twin of English **harvest**. This chapter walks both halves and shows where the seam runs. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C09-*.md.*

9.1 *die Monate* — Rome’s calendar in German

German’s numbers are homegrown (*eins*, *zwei*), and its weekday-gods are Germanic (*Donnerstag*, Thor’s day). But its **months** — like its clock-word **die Uhr** — are **borrowed straight from Latin**. Time-reckoning, again, came to the German world from Rome.

German	← Latin	who / what
<i>Januar</i>	<i>Januarius</i>	Janus , god of doors and beginnings
<i>Februar</i>	<i>Februarius</i>	the <i>Februa</i> purification festival
<i>März</i>	<i>Martius</i>	Mars , the war-god
<i>April</i>	<i>Aprilis</i>	perhaps <i>aperire</i> , “to open”
<i>Mai</i>	<i>Maius</i>	Maia , goddess of growth
<i>Juni</i>	<i>Junius</i>	Juno , queen of the gods
<i>Juli</i>	<i>Julius</i>	Julius Caesar
<i>August</i>	<i>Augustus</i>	the emperor Augustus
<i>September</i>	<i>september</i>	“ 7th ” (<i>septem</i>)
<i>Oktober</i>	<i>october</i>	“ 8th ” (<i>octo</i>)
<i>November</i>	<i>november</i>	“ 9th ” (<i>novem</i>)
<i>Dezember</i>	<i>december</i>	“ 10th ” (<i>decem</i>)

Etymology

März = Mars. German borrowed the Roman war-god’s month whole — the same god behind English **March** and behind French *mardi*. And that same god stands behind German’s own *Dienstag* (“Tuesday”), where the Romans’ Mars was *translated* into the Germanic god Tiw. The god came in twice: once by name (*März*), once by translation (*Dienstag*).

Etymology

September–Dezember = 7–10. Even in German these keep the Latin numbers *septem*, *octo*, *novem*, *decem* — because the Roman year began in March, so the “seventh” month was September. German’s *own* numbers are *sieben*, *acht*, *neun*, *zehn* — but its *month* names count in Latin.

Why it’s said this way

Three layers of the German calendar, three origins: the **numbers** are native, the **weekdays** are Germanic gods, and the **months** (along with the clock-word *Uhr*) are Latin.

9.2 *die Jahreszeiten* — the seasons go native

The months were Latin. The **seasons** swing back to **native German** — and one of them, *Herbst*, is the same word as English **harvest**. The word for “season” itself is transparent: **Jahres-zeit** = “year-time.”

German	built from	English twin
<i>der Frühling</i> (spring)	<i>früh</i> “early” + <i>-ling</i>	the “early”-season
<i>der Sommer</i> (summer)	native Germanic	summer
<i>der Herbst</i> (autumn)	native Germanic	harvest
<i>der Winter</i> (winter)	native Germanic	winter

All four are homegrown Germanic, and three are the plain twins of English *summer*, *winter*, and — the surprise — **harvest**.

Morphology Spotlight

Frühling is built from **früh** (“early”), a cousin of English **early**, plus the ending *-ling*: literally the “early-season,” the year’s first. (German

also has **der Lenz**, an old poetic word for spring.)

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Herbst ↔ **harvest**. They are the same Germanic word: the *reaping* season. English kept *harvest* but narrowed it to the *act* of gathering, and reached for the Latin-derived **autumn** to name the season; German kept the old word for the season itself. Two languages, one word, split in meaning.

Why it's said this way

So the German year splits cleanly: **Latin** for the months (like *die Uhr*, the clock), **native Germanic** for the seasons (like the numbers, and like *Mittag* “midday” and *Mitternacht* “midnight”).

Chapter 10

Family

The months were Latin tourists. Family is the opposite story: German's words for father, mother, brother and sister were never borrowed — they are inherited, and they are blood cousins of the English ones. Along the way they put a famous sound-law on display. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C10-*.md.*

10.1 *der Vater, die Mutter* — the pair that proves Grimm's law

Sounds you'll need

der Vater is said *FAH-ter*: note the spelling **V**, but it is pronounced **f**.
die Mutter is said *MOO-ter*, with a short *u* as in English *put*.

Two words, with their articles:

German	English	from
<i>der Vater</i> (masculine)	father	PIE <i>*ph₂tér</i>
<i>die Mutter</i> (feminine)	mother	PIE <i>*méh₂tēr</i>

Grammar Lens

Grimm's law, on display. Grimm's law is the great sound-shift that split the **Germanic** languages (English, German, Dutch...) off from the rest of the family. Watch what it did to the *same* ancient words that Latin kept as *pater* and *māter*:

ph₂tér* → Latin *pater* (French *père*) vs. Germanic **father / **Vater**

méh₂tēr* → Latin *māter* (French *mère*) vs. Germanic **mother / **Mutter**

Etymology

p → **f**: Latin kept the *p* (*pater*); Germanic turned it into *f* — English **father**, German **Vater** (where the *V* is simply an old spelling of that *f* sound).

t → **th** → **d**: the middle consonant became English *th* (**mother**), and then, in German’s own later shift, *d/t* (**Mutter**).

Why it’s said this way

So German and English *agree* here — both start with *f*-, both with *m*- — precisely because they are **both Germanic**, while French and Latin sit on the other side of Grimm’s line. The month names were Latin tourists; *Vater* and *Mutter* are natives.

10.2 *der Bruder, die Schwester* — and the word for “siblings”

Sounds you’ll need

BROO-der; and **Schwester** is *SHVES-ter* — German *sch* spells an English *sh* sound, and the *w* that follows is said *v*, so *Schw-* = *shv-*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

der Bruder (“brother”) ← PIE **b^hréh₂tēr* — the same root as Latin *frāter* (French *frère*), but here kept with a *b-* (Grimm’s law changed *b^h* → *b*), exactly like English **brother**.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

die Schwester (“sister”) ← PIE **swésōr*. The German *sch* spells an *sh* sound; strip it back and *Schwester* is English **sister** and Latin **soror** — all one root.

Morphology Spotlight

The collective — *die Geschwister*. German has a tidy word English lacks: **die Geschwister** = “**siblings**,” brothers-and-sisters together. It is built with the **ge-** prefix, an old **collective** marker (“a set of...”)

attached to *Schwester* — the same *ge-* that bundles mountains into a **das Gebirge** (“a mountain range”), and that lets German gather a whole family into one word.

The four family words now stand as a Germanic set beside the Romance ones:

German	English	Romance
<i>Vater / Mutter</i>	father / mother	<i>père / mère</i>
<i>Bruder / Schwester</i>	brother / sister	<i>frère / sœur</i>

Why it's said this way

Why do these match English so closely? Because both languages are **Germanic**, drawing on the same ancient roots with no Grimm's-law gap between them. Months were *borrowed* from Latin; family is *inherited* Germanic.

Chapter 11

Bread, Water, Wine

Three words from the table, and three different histories. Two of them German speakers have always had; one of them Rome carried north together with the plant it came from. On the way, the last of German's three genders finally appears. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C11-*.md.*

11.1 *das Brot* — bread, and the third gender

Sounds you'll need

broht, with a long *o* as in English *boat*; the German *r* is made far back, in the throat.

Where the Romance sisters all say a version of Latin *pānis* (French *pain*, Italian *pane*), German goes its **own Germanic way**: *Brot*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

das Brot (“bread”) ← old Germanic **braudam* — the same word that became English **bread**. No Latin here: this is a **native** word, like *Vater* and *Wasser*, out of the Germanic core the two languages share.

Grammar Lens

The third gender — *das*. You have met **der** (masculine, *der Vater*) and **die** (feminine, *die Mutter*). German has a **third**: **das**, the **neuter** — and *Brot* is one of its nouns: **das Brot**. So the article set is now complete: **der / die / das**.

Why it's said this way

German nouns are also always **Capitalized** — *Brot, Vater, Wasser* — a rule no other language in this book follows.

11.2 *das Wasser, der Wein* — one word Germans always had, one Rome brought

Two drinks, two very different histories. *Wasser* is a word Germanic speakers have **always had**; *Wein* is one Rome **carried north** with the grapevine. Side by side, they show the difference between an *inherited* word and an ancient *loan*.

Sounds you'll need

In German the letter **w** is pronounced **v**: *Wasser* = VAH-ser, *Wein* = vine. And **ei** is always said like English *eye*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

das Wasser (“water”) — the Grimm’s-law twin of English **water**: the same Germanic root **watar*, the same core meaning, both native. Like *Brot* and *Vater*, no Latin needed — and neuter, **das Wasser**.

Etymology

der Wein (“wine”) — here is the twist: *Wein* is **not** a native Germanic word. It was **borrowed from Latin *vīnum*** in Roman times, when the legions brought **viticulture** north of the Alps. The Germanic tribes took the drink *and its name* — which is exactly why English **wine**, German **Wein**, and Latin *vīnum* all match: they are one **loan**, not three cousins. (Masculine: *der Wein*.)

Why it's said this way

The lesson in one line: *Wasser* is a word Germans **always had**; *Wein* is a word Rome **gave** them — the vine came with a vocabulary.

11.2. DAS WASSER, DER WEIN — ONE WORD GERMANS ALWAYS HAD, ONE ROME BROUGHT 55

German	English	history
<i>das Brot</i>	bread	inherited Germanic (<i>*braudam</i>)
<i>das Wasser</i>	water	inherited Germanic (<i>*watar</i>)
<i>der Wein</i>	wine	borrowed from Latin <i>vīnum</i>

Chapter 12

Numbers Eleven to Twenty

Why are English *eleven* and *twelve* so strange — why not “oneteen, twoteen”? German has the identical oddity, and because the two languages are Germanic twins, learning one *explains* the other. Then, at thirteen, both settle into a rule that never breaks. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C12-*.md.*

12.1 *elf* und *zwölf* — “one left over,” “two left over”

Sounds you’ll need

elf is said as it looks. *zwölf* begins *tsv*- (German *z* = *ts*, *w* = *v*) and carries the rounded *ö*: shape your lips for *oh* and say *eh*.

Morphology Spotlight

elf (11) ← old Germanic *ainlif* = *ain* (“one”) + *lif*.

zwölf (12) ← *twalif* = *twa* (“two”) + *lif*.

And **-lif** means “to leave, to remain.” So *elf* = “one left over” and *zwölf* = “two left over.”

Left over from **what**? From **ten** — from your ten fingers. You count to ten, you run out of fingers, and you have **one left**. Eleven is literally the leftover.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

English says exactly the same thing: *eleven* ← *ain-lif*, *twelve* ← *twa-lif*. Not similar words — *the same words*, inherited side by side. The Germanic-twin pattern that turned up in *Vater/father* and *Wasser/water* reaches even the counting.

Grammar Lens

And then it stops. The leftover-trick covers only **two** numbers. From **13** on, German turns completely regular — and so does English.

12.2 *dreizehn* → *zwanzig* — the pattern that never breaks

After the two leftovers, German settles into a rule so regular you can generate every number without being taught it: **digit** + **zehn**. And English does the identical thing — because *-teen* **is** *ten*.

	German	English	build
13	<i>dreizehn</i>	thirteen	<i>drei</i> + <i>zehn</i>
14	<i>vierzehn</i>	fourteen	<i>vier</i> + <i>zehn</i>
15	<i>fünfzehn</i>	fifteen	<i>fünf</i> + <i>zehn</i>
16	<i>sechzehn</i>	sixteen	<i>sechs</i> + <i>zehn</i> (the <i>s</i> drops)
17	<i>siebzehn</i>	seventeen	<i>sieben</i> + <i>zehn</i> (shortened)
18	<i>achtzehn</i>	eighteen	<i>acht</i> + <i>zehn</i>
19	<i>neunzehn</i>	nineteen	<i>neun</i> + <i>zehn</i>
20	<i>zwanzig</i>	twenty	← <i>twaintig</i> , “two tens”

Sounds you’ll need

The *z* of *zehn* and *zwanzig* is *ts*: *TSAYN*, *TSVAHN-tsikh*. The final *-ig* of *zwanzig* is normally said like the soft *ich*-sound, *-ikh*.

Every one of them is a digit + *zehn* — and the English column is the same compound with *-teen*, which is just **ten** again (*thir-teen* = “three-ten”). Only two small wearings-down: *sech(s)zehn* and *sieb(en)zehn* clip a sound for easier speech, exactly as English *thir-* and *fif-* did to *three* and *five*.

Morphology Spotlight

zwanzig (20) ← *twaintig*, “**two tens**” — the *-zig* is another worn-down form of *ten*, matching English *twen-ty*, whose *-ty* is *ten* as well.

Why it’s said this way

The contrast worth noticing. The Romance sisters all **break** their pattern partway through the teens — Portuguese at 16, French and Italian at 17, swapping over to a “ten-and-six” style. **German never breaks.** Two leftovers, then one clean rule all the way to twenty — and English marches beside it the entire distance.

Chapter 13

Colours

Four colours — *schwarz*, *weiß*, *rot*, *blau* — and a small surprise inside them. German’s colour words are all home-grown Germanic, with no Latin borrowed in; and two of them travelled the other way, out of Germanic and into the Romance languages. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C13-*.md.*

13.1 *schwarz*, *weiß* — black and white, and the word German lent away

German’s colour words are **home-grown** — no Latin here. But one of them has a sibling that emigrated: a German word for “shining” became the word for **white** in French, Italian and Portuguese.

Sounds you’ll need

schwarz = *SHVARTS*: the *schw*- cluster is “sh” + “v,” and the final *z* is always “ts.”

weiß = *vice*: German *w* is English “v,” *ei* is the vowel of English *eye*, and the *ß* (*Eszett*) is a sharp “ss.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

schwarz (“black”) ← Proto-Germanic **swartaz*. Its English cousin survives in **swarthy** (“dark-complexioned”). Further back it is related to Latin *sordēs* (“dirt”) — the root of English **sordid**. Black and grubby, from one idea.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

weiß (“white”) ← Proto-Germanic **hwītaz* — *exactly* English **white**.
The same word in different spelling clothes.

Sounds you’ll need

The *ß* (*Eszett*) marks a sharp *s* after a long vowel. So *weiß* rhymes with English *vice*, not with the second half of *vice-versa*. In Switzerland you will see it written **weiss** — the letter is optional there.

The word that emigrated

German also has **blank** — “shiny, polished, bare.” That word, in its Frankish form *blank* (“shining”), was **borrowed into Romance**, where it pushed Latin’s own *albus* out and became:

Language	“white”
French	blanc
Italian	bianco
Portuguese	branco
German	<i>blank</i> — still just “ shiny ”

Why it’s said this way

This is the **reverse** of the usual flow. Latin normally lends *to* Germanic (*Fenster* ← *fenestra*, *Wein* ← *vīnum*). Here Germanic lent *to* Latin’s daughters — and German kept the original meaning while they turned it into a colour.

Practise them on something you can already name: *der Wein ist weiß* (“the wine is white”), and *weiß* · *white* said side by side, so you can hear that it is one word.

13.2 *rot, blau* — an ancient cousin and a second emigrant

Two more native German colours. One is related to the French word for red — genuinely, not by borrowing. The other is a **second** German word the Romance languages took.

Sounds you'll need

rot = *roht*, with a long “o” as in English *road*.

blau = *blow* (rhyming with *cow*): German *au* is the vowel of English *house*.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

rot ← Proto-Germanic **raudaz* ← Proto-Indo-European **h₁rewd^h*-. That root is one of the oldest colour words we can reconstruct, and it went everywhere:

Language	Word
German	rot
English	red , <i>rust</i> , <i>ruddy</i>
Latin	<i>ruber</i> , <i>rubeus</i> → French rouge , <i>ruby</i> , <i>rubric</i>

So *rot* and *rouge* are **cousins**, not borrowings — they split apart thousands of years before either language existed. Red is the colour humans name first, after black and white.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

blau ← Proto-Germanic **blēwaz*. Like *blank* in the last lesson, this word was **borrowed into Romance**.

Language	“blue”
German	blau
French	bleu
Italian	blu
English	blue — taken from French , not from German

Why it's said this way

English is the odd one here: it had Germanic *blāw* available but borrowed the French form instead. The word went Germanic → French → English, coming home in disguise. Portuguese went a different way entirely — its blue is **azul**, from **Arabic**.

The chapter in one table

German	Source	Did Romance borrow it?
<i>schwarz</i>	Germanic <i>*swartaz</i>	no
<i>weiß</i>	Germanic <i>*hwītaz</i>	no — but <i>blank</i> went instead
<i>rot</i>	Germanic <i>*raudaz</i>	no — Latin had its own cousin
<i>blau</i>	Germanic <i>*blēwaz</i>	yes — <i>bleu</i> , <i>blu</i>

Say all four together — *schwarz*, *weiß*, *rot*, *blau* — and then the cousins that prove the family: *rot* · *red* · *rouge*. Next chapter: putting these onto the things you already name.

Chapter 14

To Have, and How Old You Are

German’s workhorse verb *haben*, “to have” — which hides the best false cognate in the whole course — and then the one everyday sentence where German *refuses* to use it, siding with English against every Romance sister. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C14-*.md.*

14.1 *haben* — “to have,” the twin of English *have*

Sounds you’ll need

HAH-ben, with a long “a” as in English *father*. In *hast* and *hat* the vowel stays short and the final *t* is crisp.

Singular	Plural
ich habe	wir haben
du hast	ihr habt
er/sie hat	sie/Sie haben

Morphology Spotlight

Mostly regular, with **two irregulars**: *du hast* and *er hat* **drop the b**. English does the identical thing — *have* but *has*, and *hast* in older English. Two languages, one shortcut, inherited together.

The trap: *haben* is not *habēre*

Language	Verb	Meaning
German	haben	to have
Latin	habēre	to have

Same consonants, same meaning. **They are not related.** It is a coincidence — one of the most famous in linguistics.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

haben ← Germanic **habjaną* ← Proto-Indo-European **kap-*, “**to seize**.” That root’s Latin child is *capere* — which gives English **capture**, **captive**, **capable**, **accept**.

habēre ← Proto-Indo-European **ǵʰabh-*, whose English descendant is... **give**.

So German *haben* is a cousin of **capture**, and Latin *habēre* — the source of French *avoir* and Italian *avere* — is a cousin of **give**. The two words that look most alike come from **opposite** directions.

Using it

German nouns are capitalised and take their gender:

Ich habe einen Bruder. — “I have a brother.”
Wir haben Brot und Wein. — “We have bread and wine.”

Say the whole set aloud — *ich habe, du hast, er hat, wir haben, ihr habt, sie haben* — listening for the dropped **b**: *habe ... hast ... hat*.

14.2 *ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt* — being your years

You have just learned *haben*. Here is the everyday sentence where German **won’t** let you use it — and where German and English stand alone against all four Romance languages.

Wie alt bist du? — literally “How old are you?”
Ich bin zwanzig Jahre alt. — “I am twenty years old.”

Word for word, that is the **English sentence**. Not a coincidence — both languages inherited the same way of saying it. You can shorten it to *Ich bin zwanzig*, exactly as English drops “years old.”

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

Jahr ← Germanic **jēra* = English **year**.

alt ← Germanic **aldaz* = English **old**.

Alt has a Latin cousin too: *alere*, “to nourish, grow” — which gives English **adult** (“grown up”) and **old** itself. Growing and ageing, one idea.

Morphology Spotlight

Jahre is the plural of *Jahr*, and German capitalises it because it is a noun. The same word sits inside *Jahreszeiten* — “year’s-times,” the German word for the seasons.

The split, laid out

Language	How age works	Literally
German	<i>ich bin ... Jahre alt</i>	I am ...
English	<i>I am twenty</i>	I am ...
French	<i>j'ai vingt ans</i>	I have ...
Spanish	<i>tengo veinte años</i>	I have ...
Italian	<i>ho venti anni</i>	I have ...
Portuguese	<i>tenho vinte anos</i>	I have ...

Why it’s said this way

Romance has its years; Germanic is its years. Age as something you carry versus age as something you are — and German, which borrowed its month names from Latin, keeps its **own** logic here. The verb it uses is *sein* (*bin*), not *haben*; that verb gets a chapter of its own shortly.

Chapter 15

The Two Past Tenses

German has two ways of talking about the past: the *Perfekt*, built from *haben* plus a wrapped-up participle, and the *Präteritum*, a single word with a *-te* on the end. They mean the same thing. What separates them is where you are and whether you are writing. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C15-*.md.*

15.1 *ich habe gesagt* — the past built from “have”

German’s everyday past tense works almost exactly like the English perfect — except for two things German does that English doesn’t.

Morphology Spotlight

The recipe: **haben** (conjugated) + **past participle**, and the participle goes **last**.

Infinitive	Participle
<i>sagen</i>	gesagt
<i>machen</i>	gemacht
<i>lernen</i>	gelernt
<i>wohnen</i>	gewohnt

Regular (weak) verbs take **ge-** in front and **-t** behind. The participle is **wrapped**, not merely suffixed — what grammarians call a *circumfix*.

German	English
<i>ich habe gesagt</i>	I said
<i>du hast gesagt</i>	you said
<i>wir haben gesagt</i>	we said

Grammar Lens

1. The participle goes to the end. Not next to the verb — the *end of the clause*:

*Ich habe gestern Deutsch **gelernt**.*

(word for word: “I have yesterday German **learned**.”)

Everything else piles up in the middle, and the participle waits at the back. English cannot do this: “I have yesterday German learned” is not a sentence.

2. It means the plain past. *Ich habe gesagt* translates as “**I said**,” not only “I have said.” Where English keeps *I said* and *I have said* apart, spoken German mostly uses the *Perfekt* for both.

The *ge-* that English lost**The word, taken apart — and its English cousins**

ge- ← Germanic **ga-*, a prefix meaning “**together, completely**.” It marked an action as **finished** — perfective — which is exactly what a past participle is for. English had it too, as *y-*, and then dropped it. Two fossils survive:

Word	Hiding inside
enough	Old English <i>genōg</i>
<i>yclept</i> (archaic, “named”)	<i>gecleopod</i>

So English once wrapped its participles the same way, and German simply never stopped. Say the wrap out loud — **ge-sag-t** — and then the fossil: *en-ough* ← *genōg*.

15.2 *ich sagte* — the simple past

German has a **second** past tense, the *Präteritum* — and choosing between the two is about **where you are** and **whether you are writing**, not about meaning.

	<i>Präteritum</i>	<i>Perfekt</i>
I said	<i>ich sagte</i>	<i>ich habe gesagt</i>
I made	<i>ich machte</i>	<i>ich habe gemacht</i>
I had	<i>ich hatte</i>	<i>ich habe gehabt</i>

Weak verbs add **-te**. Same meaning as the *Perfekt*; different register.

Morphology Spotlight

That **-te** is the **dental preterite** — the Germanic way of making a past tense by adding a *t/d* sound:

German: *sag* → ***sagte***

English: *walk* → ***walked***

Dutch: *werk* → ***werkte***

This is a **Germanic invention**. Latin had nothing like it — Romance builds its past from inherited perfect endings instead. So *sagte* and *walked* are the same machinery, and French *parla* or Spanish *habló* are a completely different one.

Who says which

Tense	Where it lives
<i>Perfekt</i>	everyday speech — dominant, especially in the south
<i>Präteritum</i>	rarer in speech; standard in narrative writing

In southern Germany, Austria and Switzerland the *Präteritum* has largely vanished from conversation. Further north it survives better. And in books, it is the normal past tense. A few verbs resist everywhere: *war*, *hatte*, and the modal verbs stay common even in speech.

The same retreat, three times

Language	Simple past	Replaced in speech by
German	<i>Präteritum</i>	<i>Perfekt</i>
French	<i>passé simple</i>	<i>passé composé</i>
Italian	<i>passato remoto</i>	<i>passato prossimo</i>

Why it's said this way

Two Romance languages and one **Germanic** one, doing the same thing over the same centuries — and **not** by coincidence. Southern Germany, France and northern Italy are **neighbours**, and the change spread through that connected block by **contact**. Linguists call this an *areal* change: it travels across language boundaries because the speakers do, which is why a Germanic language and two Romance ones line up here while Spanish and Portuguese, out at the **western edge**, largely kept their simple past. It also explains the map *inside* German: the *Präteritum* is weakest in the **south**, nearest the centre of the change, and strongest in the north.

Practise the pair back to back — *ich **sagte** ... ich **habe gesagt**, Er machte das ... Er hat das gemacht* — and hear that nothing about the meaning has moved. Next: the verbs that build their perfect with *sein*, not *haben*.

Chapter 16

To Be, and the Past That Takes It

sein, “to be” — the partner of *haben*, and the most irregular verb in German, because it is not really one verb at all but three ancient ones sharing a paradigm. Then the second half of the past tense: the family of verbs that builds its perfect on *sein* instead of *haben*. *Practice lessons: lessons/GE-C16-*.md.*

16.1 *sein* — “to be,” three verbs under one roof

Sounds you’ll need

sein = *zine*: German *s* before a vowel is English “z,” and *ei* is the vowel of English *eye*. In *ist* and *bist* the final *t* is crisp; *ich* ends in the soft ich-sound.

Singular	Plural
ich bin	wir sind
du bist	ihr seid
er/sie/es ist	sie/Sie sind

Past: *ich war*, *du warst*, *er war*, *wir waren*.

Look at that with fresh eyes. *Bin*, *ist*, *war* — those do not look like forms of the same word, and they aren’t.

The word, taken apart — and its English cousins

ist, **sind**, **seid**, **sein** ← Proto-Indo-European **h₁es-*, “to be” — which also gave Latin *est*, *sunt* and French *est*, *sont*.

bin, **bist** ← **b^huH-*, “to grow, become” — which also gave English **be**

and Latin *fuī*.

war, waren ← **wes-*, “to dwell, remain” — which also gave English **was, were**.

Morphology Spotlight

Three separate ancient verbs, each contributing a slice of the paradigm. When one verb’s forms are filled in from another verb, that is **suppletion** — the same thing English does in *go / went*.

Why it’s said this way

And notice that *bin/bist* has a cousin further afield. Latin *fuī* is the source of Spanish **fui**, “I was / I went.” German *bin* and Spanish *fui* descend from the same PIE root **b^huH-* — one landed in the present, the other in the past.

Grammar Lens

Why “be” verbs are the messiest words in every language. This is not bad luck; it is a rule: *the most-used words are the most irregular*. Regularity spreads by analogy — you meet an unfamiliar verb and guess its forms from the pattern. But you never have to guess at “to be.” You hear it a hundred times a day, so the odd old shapes are reinforced faster than analogy can sand them down. Rare words get regularized; common words are protected fossils.

Run the six forms until they are automatic — *ich bin, du bist, er ist, wir sind, ihr seid, sie sind* — and put them to work: *Ich bin müde* (“I am tired”), *Das ist gut* (“that is good”).

16.2 *ich bin gegangen* — the perfect built on *sein*

The last chapter built the perfect with *haben*: *ich habe gelernt*. A particular family of verbs takes **sein** instead — and the line it draws will look familiar to anyone who has met French.

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The rule: verbs of motion and change of state take *sein*.

gehen (“to go”) is the model:

German	English
<i>ich bin gegangen</i>	I went / I have gone
<i>du bist gegangen</i>	you went
<i>er ist gegangen</i>	he went
<i>wir sind gegangen</i>	we went

The rest of the family:

Verb	Perfect	English
<i>kommen</i>	<i>ich bin gekommen</i>	I came
<i>fahren</i>	<i>ich bin gefahren</i>	I travelled, drove
<i>bleiben</i>	<i>ich bin geblieben</i>	I stayed
<i>werden</i>	<i>ich bin geworden</i>	I became
<i>sein</i> itself	<i>ich bin gewesen</i>	I have been

Motion (*gehen*, *kommen*, *fahren*), change of state (*werden*) — and then a small set that breaks the pattern and simply has to be learned: **sein** and **bleiben**, which are the *opposite* of change, plus *gelingen* (“succeed”), *geschehen* / *passieren* (“happen”) and *begegnen* (“meet”).

No agreement — the German simplification

Here is a place where German is *easier* than French:

	French	German
he went	<i>il est allé</i>	<i>er ist gegangen</i>
she went	<i>elle est allée</i>	<i>sie ist gegangen</i>
they went	<i>ils sont allés</i>	<i>sie sind gegangen</i>

Grammar Lens

French makes the participle agree with the subject. **In the perfect, German makes it agree with nothing** — *gegangen* is *gegangen* for every person and every gender. German participles *do* still take endings when used as adjectives in front of a noun — *ein geschriebener Brief* (“a written letter”), *der angekommene Zug* (“the arrived train”), *die eingeschlafene Katze* (“the fallen-asleep cat”). It is specifically the perfect where the ending is gone. Old High German did inflect the participle here, at least variably; German lost that, along with most of its

other adjective-like endings in this position.

Why it's said this way

And note what did **not** happen: German didn't get this from Latin. The *haben*-perfect and the *sein*-perfect are native Germanic developments that grew up **alongside** the Romance ones — neighbouring languages drifting the same way through centuries of contact, the same areal spread that made the simple past retreat in French, German and Italian together. Two things to carry forward: the **split** is parallel, the **agreement** is not shared.

Practise the contrast until the choice of helper is a reflex — *ich **habe** gelernt ... ich **bin** gegangen* — and the comparison that shows off German's one economy here: *elle est allée ... sie ist gegangen*, with no ending at all.

That is where this volume pauses. In sixteen chapters you have gone from *guten Tag* to two working past tenses, and the method has not changed once: take the word apart, find the English cousin sleeping inside it, and let the family tree do the memorising for you. The next volume picks the thread back up with describing what you see.